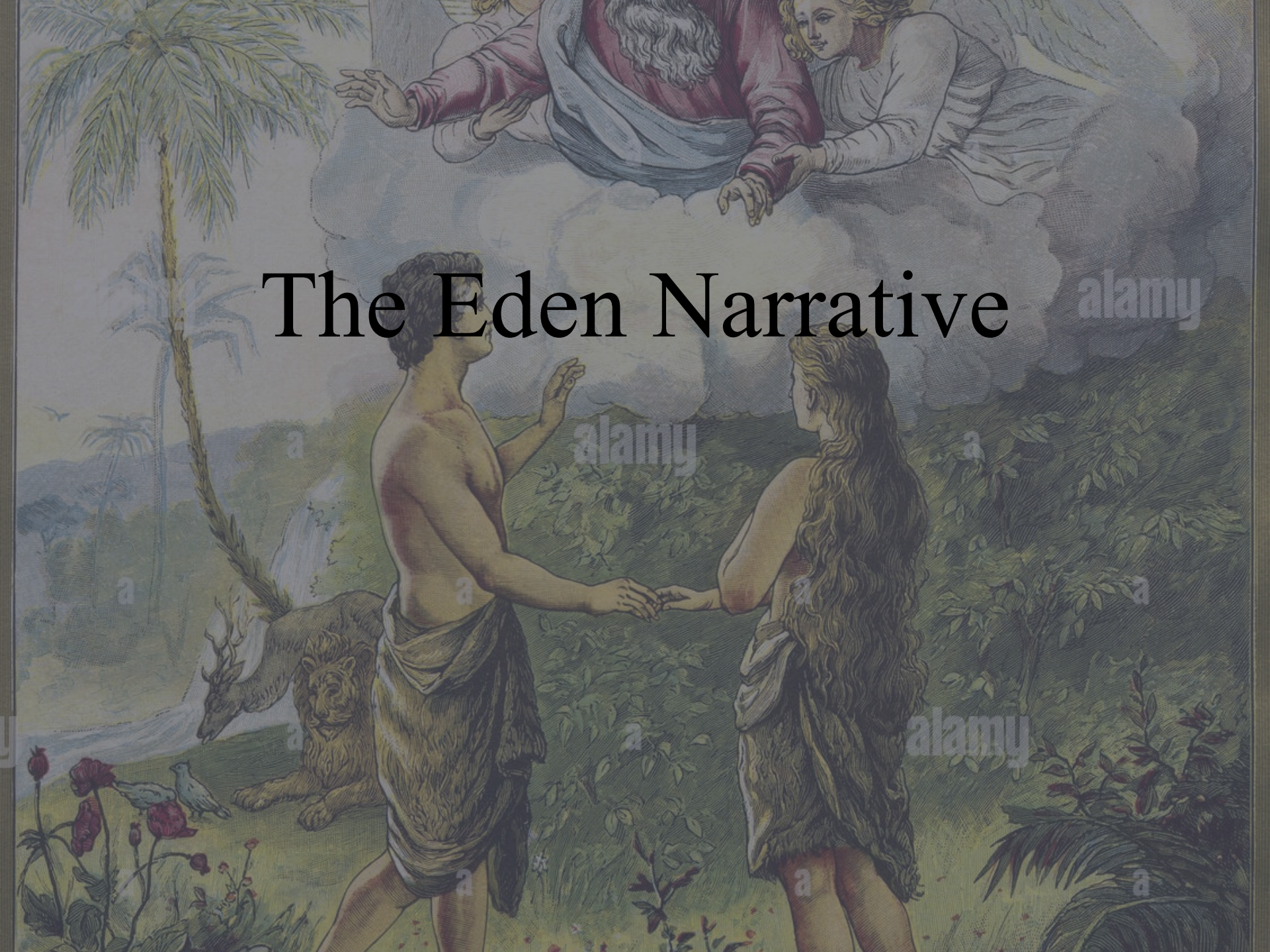
The Eden Narrative



The Set-up

- Very long . . . ***all*** of Genesis 2

Extremely Important!

- Why such an extensive setup??
- It explains how to understand the Fall.
  - the ***nature*** of the Fall itself.
  - the ***effects*** of the Fall.

The Set-up

Heading *(2:4a)*

"These are the _____ of the earth and the heavens."

- Hebrew: *toledot*
  - What develops from, as in birth
- The *toledot* heading accomplishes two functions:
  - Marks the beginning of a major section
  - Indicates that something is about to happen
    - Immediately following the creation of the heavens and earth . . . "this is ***what happened to*** the earth and the heavens," specifically ***taking up the issues of Day 6*** of creation.

In the day the Lord God made the earth and the heavens,
and all the shrubs of the field,
before they were in the earth,
and all the cultivated grains of the field,
before they sprouted,
(for the Lord God had not yet caused it to rain upon the earth,
and there was no man to serve the ground,
but ground water went up from the earth
and watered all the face of the earth)
the Lord God formed the man, dust from the ground.
And he breathed into his nostrils breath of life.
And the man became a living being.

In the day the Lord God made the earth and the heavens,

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What "day" was that??

The Set-up

Develops Day 6

- Focuses especially on ***the items*** presented in ***the speech*** of Day 6 *(the most important features)*
  - Animals
  - Humankind
  - Plants as food
  - Relationship between animals, humankind, and plants as food
- Develops the ***key themes*** of Day 6:
  - The unity in plurality of humanity,
  - Plants and trees as food for humanity,
  - Humanity's dominion over animals and the earth

The Set-up

Introduction (2:4b-7)

- Provides a background for the story
  - Presents some things "lacking"
    - A common literary technique, introducing a story with a deficiency which is resolved at the end
      - sometimes serves as the theme of the story,
      - sometimes puts the story within a context,
      - sometimes denote the beginning and end of the story.
  - No herbs in the field because
    - No rain to water the ground
    - No man to till the earth
  - ***BUT***, the water problem is immediately resolved

The Set-up

Introduction (2:4b-7)

An introduction in terms of two things which are lacking . . .

with one immediately resolved . . .

rhetorically signals the reader to . . .*(?)*

***concentrate on the unresolved issue*.**

Where's the man?

Observation

The Essence of the Man

- very different presentation from Day 6
  - formed from dirt
  - animated by God's breath
  - therefore, both elevated and debased
    - essentially dirt, but receiving God's life

But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the surpassing greatness of the power may be of God, and not from us. *(2 Cor 4:7)*

The Set-up

Placement of the Man

- Creation of man immediately following the presentation of ***a lack of man to till the earth*** makes the reader expect . . . ??

  the placement of man on the earth, tilling the ground.
- As expected based on the "lack," man is created.
- ***Not*** as expected, he is placed in ***a garden***.

A Surprise!! A Blessing!!

The Lord God caused to sprout from the ground all trees,
pleasant to sight and good for food,
and the tree of life in the middle of the garden,
and the tree of the knowledge of good and bad.
Now a river goes out of Eden to water the garden.
And from there it separates and becomes four heads.
The name of the one, Pishon
It surrounds all the land of Havilah, where there is gold.
(Now the gold of that land is good.
Pearls and lapis lazuli are there.)
And the name of the second, Gihon.
It surrounds the land of Cush.
And the name of the third, Tigris.
It goes on the east of Assyria.
And the name of the fourth, it is Euphrates

Description of the Garden

- The garden is portrayed as . . .

  the ultimate place of blessing

- The blessing of fruit trees:
  - Portrayed as prominent *(mentioned first)*
  - In the main line narrative and not background information.
  - Represents food apart from laborious labor
  - Presented ***explicitly*** as attractive and good for food, both positive characteristics from man's perspective.
  - Presented in a way which portrays life, in contrast to death
    - Presents continued life (tree of life)
    - Forebodes disaster (tree of knowledge of good and bad)

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- Flowing water
  - In contrast to a lack of water affecting growth, Eden is presented as just the opposite.
  - Not only is Eden watered, but it ***supplies*** water to the rest of the earth.
  - The water starts out as one river but divides into four, picturing universal multiplication of life-giving resources.
  - The regions featured are characterized as lands of abundance.

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- The garden is portrayed as . . .

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- Communion with God
  - Although presented by implication, it is a place where God and humankind commune openly and freely.

A place

  - where man does not have to toil laboriously for food

    (versus the implication of the introduction)
  - that is the source of life for the rest of the earth
  - of communion with God

Description of the Garden

And the Lord God took the man.
And he caused him to rest in the garden of Eden
to serve it
and to keep it.

Description of the Garden

And the Lord God took the man.
And he ***caused him to rest*** *in the garden of Eden*
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- Not working the field for food, but given rest in paradise
- But rest is not his function . . . it to serve and keep the garden

To Serve

- What is the meaning of “to serve”?
- Hebrew: *avad*
  - Think of serving food to the homeless
- Implications:
  - The garden is not made for the man
  - The man is made to serve the garden
  - Once again, ***it’s not about us***.

To Keep

- What is the meaning of "to keep"?
- Hebrew: *shamar*
  - to pay very close attention to something
  - to maintain the status quo (protect, adhere to)
- Implications:
  - The garden is for the man's use
  - The man is made to maintain God's paradise
  - Once again, ***it's not about us***.

Description of the Garden

And the Lord God took the man.
And he ***caused him to rest*** *in the garden of Eden*
to serve it
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- Not working the field for food, but given rest in paradise
- But rest is not his function . . . it to serve and keep the garden
- ***In paradise, work is rest!***
- ***Serving God means he provides our needs!***

Come to me, all you that are weary and heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me. My yoke is easy and my burden is light, and you will find rest for your souls. *Matt 12:28–30*

Don’t be careful about your life, what you should eat and what ye should drink; nor for your body what you should put on. . . . These things are what the nations seek after. Your heavenly Father knows that you have need of all these things. So seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you. Matt 6:25–33

Important Warning

And the Lord God commanded the man, saying:

"From every tree of the garden you may freely eat. But from the tree of the knowledge of good and bad, you may not eat from it. For, in the day that you eat from it, you will surely die."

Note:

- Once again, food is prominent
- Again, food is emphasized as in the creation account
- The only prohibition deals with food

Important Warning

- The story is introduced with two deficiencies, one which is resolved immediately.
- Man is created . .
  - anticipating resolution of the second deficiency,
  - but is surprisingly placed in a place of blessing, characterized by rest and food with minimal work.
- ***But***, **DANGER: Don't eat of that tree!**
  - the tree of the knowledge of good and bad
  - independently assessing what is beneficial and detrimental

Don't feed yourself with your own will!
If you do, you'll die!

Unexpected Complication

"And the Lord God said:

"It is not good for the man to be alone.

I will make him a helper that is suitable for him."

And the Lord God formed from the ground

every living animal of the field,

and every bird of the heavens.

And he brought them to the man to see what he would call them.

(Now whatever the man called each living creature,

that was its name.)

And the man called names to all cattle,

and to the birds of the heavens,

and to all the animals of the field.

But, for the man, a helper suitable for him was not found.

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Suitable Helper

- "Helper"
  - Hebrew: *ezer*
    - helper, but not necessarily subordinate
    - God is often called our helper (*Pss 33:20; 70:5; 115:9, 10, 11; 121:1, 2; 146:5*)
    - better translation: "supporter"
- Implications:
  - Not companionship . . .
  - ***rather***, the man needs help . . .
  - help to fulfill his work of service

Unexpected Complication

- Addressing that need plays out as follows:
  - God creates animals and brings them to the man
  - The man makes assessments
  - The man finds none suitable
  - God creates the woman
  - The man makes an assessment
  - The narrator adds a comment

And the Lord God caused a deep sleep to fall on the man.
And he slept.
And he took one of his ribs.
And he closed up the flesh in its place.
And the Lord God built the rib which he took from the man into a woman.
And he brought her to the man.
And the man said:
"This time it is bone of my bone, and flesh of my flesh.
Because of this she will be called ishah
because from ish this one was taken."

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And the man said:
"This time it is bone of my bone, and flesh of my flesh.
Because of this she will be called ***ishah***
because from ***ish*** *this one was taken."*

Observations

- Making an assessment
  - The assessment is *not* in independence.
  - God calls upon him to make the assessment.
- Formation of the helper
  - not from dirt and given life, as was the man . . .
  - but . . .
    - from a living thing
    - from the strongest part of the man
    - and from his side
  - not made as a subordinate, but as a supporter
- Man and Woman
  - both introduced in terms of their function
    - man to serve God
    - woman to help the man serve God

Narrator's Comments

Therefore, a man will forsake his father and his mother
and cling to his wife.
And they will be one flesh.
And the two of them, the man and his wife, were naked,
and they were not ashamed.

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Therefore, a man ***will forsake his father and his mother***
and ***cling to his wife****.*
And they will be one flesh.
And the two of them, the man and his wife, were naked,
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- Very different from the common perspective
- The man must leave his childhood support . . .
  and cling to his wife for support.

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And the two of them, the man and his wife, ***were naked****,*
and they were ***not ashamed****.*

- Transitional statement, setting up the story itself
- Places a focus on unity in plurality of humanity *(image of God)*
- Characterizes humanity as vulnerable, but content

Summary of the Set-up

- The development of Day 6 of creation
  - “This is what happened to creation in humanity’s hands.”
- The Man,
  - created and unexpectedly placed in paradise
  - restful work
  - needs provided for
  - communion with God
  - with the woman’s help, unity in plurality as God’s representative